Good News Versus Bad

By Erin Barker

(Pg 201-205) When I was about twelve years old, my mom said she wanted to talk to me about something. My mom and I didn't have a lot of talks. I loved her very much, but she was one of those corporate working moms with the beeper and the pants suit. She yelled important things into phones, and she was away a lot on business.

But she sat me down in the living room, and she told me that she was pregnant. And it was kind of strange the way she said it, almost like she wasn't that happy about it. It had been eight years since my brother was born, but even I could remember how excited everybody had been—how everyone had ideas for names, how all the grandparents had flown in from out of town, how barely a day went by that we didn't get some kind of massive delivery of balloons or a giant stuffed animal. But this time there were no balloons. There weren't even any cards.

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But I was still very excited. I had never expected to have another sibling after my little brother, and I was optimistic that this time I'd get one who could throw a baseball. So I told everyone the big news. I told everyone at school, everyone at church, my Girl Scout troop, the next-door neighbors, the kid who mowed our lawn -everybody. And they were all just as excited as I was. Except after a while, I started to notice that when these people would inevitably congratulate my dad on the big news, there would be this sort of whispered exchange, and then that person would say, "Oh my God, I'm so sorry." And I didn't know what that meant until one day when my dad took me out for ice cream.

INTRODUCTION

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My dad was my best friend when I was a kid. He was the dad who would read to us every night before bed and would listen very seriously to my thoughts on

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the Roald Dahl masterpiece *James and the Giant Peach*. He taught me how to throw a baseball, and at one point really believed he could teach my brother the same. He taught us that Darth Vader had to wear that suit because he had been injured in a car accident, and so my brother and I better always wear our seat belts unless we wanted to end up like him.

Because my dad and I were so close I knew what ice cream meant. Every time my dad has bad news he takes us out for ice cream. It's kind of his M.O. Don't ever go to the Cold Stone Creamery with my dad -just don't do it. Unless you want to find out that Grandpa has cancer, or your dog's been put to sleep, or your nanny's been fired for stealing your mother's jewelry, just don't go.

So we get our ice cream of doom, and my dad takes a deep breath, and he says, "The baby your mother is pregnant with is not mine." And I can see him looking at me trying to see if I understand at twelve years old what he means.

As it just so happened, I had conveniently just

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learned what sex was in school, when my science teacher forced poor Craig Berken to read it out loud from our biology textbook. I can still remember the exact words, as read in Craig's shaky, giggly voice: *The man jiggles his penis inside the woman's vagina.*

Yes, jiggles. Even at that age I was like, *I really feel like that is not the right word for this context.* "Jiggles" is a word that's neither sexy nor scientific, and probably only belongs in a Jell-O commercial. But you know, it did the trick. I learned what sex was, and I understood exactly what was going on here. I understood what my dad was telling me, and I could tell how hard it was for him to tell me.

And then he says, "Do you know who the father is?" And I realize with sudden clarity that I do know.

"Andy?" I said, and my dad nodded.

Andy was my mom's coworker, this British guy about ten years younger than her, who would take me and my mom and my brother on little trips and buy us expensive presents. He'd even, oddly enough, gone to church with us. I thought he was our friend.

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I realized now that I'd been wrong, and that I'd been stupid not to realize it. And as a result, not only had I failed to prevent this disaster (and like every child I truly believed in my heart that I could have, with a well-timed tantrum or the right number of slammed doors), but I'd also made it infinitely worse for the person who deserved it the least, my father. I'd been coming home for months saying things like, "Dad, look at the awesome Lego castle Andy brought us." "Dad, guess what, we taught Andy how to play baseball today," never noticing the tense silence. Not to mention I'd publicly humiliated him by telling everyone about my mother's pregnancy.

I was devastated, and I was no longer excited about the new baby. Shortly after this my parents got divorced, and my mom bought a house down the street from my dad's because the neighborhood didn't already have enough to talk about. One day I went down and there was cake on the table and my mom said, "Andy and I got married today. Do you want a piece of the wedding cake?"

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No, I did not want a piece of the cake of lies.

The next time I went down, I was met with an even bigger surprise, this time in the form of a strange pink baby who I was told was my new sister.

"Do you want to hold her?" my mom asked.

No, I did not want to hold her. I didn't want to look at her, at this baby who had broken my father's heart. I loathed this horrible creature, and I decided then that I always would. I made a commitment in that moment to hate this baby for the rest of my life, possibly longer.

There was just one problem ... I don't know if you've ever tried to hate a baby, but it is difficult. Because everything they do is magical. And this was especially true in the case of my sister, Emma, who had a little Pebbles Flintstone ponytail on top of her head. Every night that I was at my mom's house, she would refuse to go to sleep until I came and sang to her.

Soon I found myself bonding with my mom for the first time in a long time over our mutual love for

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Emma and our mutual hatred of the Teletubbies. Slowly all my anger fell down like dominoes. When I forgave my sister, it was easier to forgive my mom, and when I forgave my mom, it was easier to forgive myself. I'll admit I never quite forgave Andy, but that was okay because it turned out that his stay with us was only temporary anyway. He met another married woman with children and started going to church with them, and presumably started this story all over with someone else.

As for my dad, I never had to ask for his forgiveness. It was always there.

Emma is fourteen years old now, and she's gone from Teletubbies to *Twilight*. Clearly she has questionable taste-in a few years it'll probably be Dan Brown novels. But despite that, we're great friends, and I love her very much, and I can't regret anything that happened because without it we wouldn't have her. Although she never did learn how to throw a baseball.

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AWARD HISTORY

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